

education

SEX EDUCATION

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Those who have tuned in to the recent debates about sex education in schools could be forgiven for assuming it is an imported novelty that the deeply conservative school education system is not ready for and that it was only the wise and knowing UNICEF, which saw a yawning gap in the system and finally addressed it. This assumption, in turn, led to angry protests from seven state governments, albeit more than two years after the new Adolescence Education Programme (AEP)—a euphemism for the more discomfiting term sex education—was first introduced.

Right? Wrong. The process towards building an AEP curriculum began in 1993, when NCERT organised the first nationwide seminar involving educationists, students, parents, teachers, and even sexologists. Their modules, prepared in 1999, after being finalised in five regional seminars between 1994 and 1996, were in circulation without much controversy until National AIDS Control Organisation (NACO), UNICEF and the Ministry of Human Resource Development (HRD) decided to update them with new material dispatched in 2005 to achieve the Government's stated goal of "no new HIV infections by 2007". This had entailed that by 2005 "every person in the population should be aware of how to protect themselves" (from minutes of an inter-ministerial meeting on HIV/AIDS in November 2004). The United Nations Population Fund provided allocations of Rs 42.30 crore and Rs 55.20 crore for the years 2005-06 and 2006-07 for over 40,000 schools. According to the UNAIDS version, even this passed off without much controversy until UNICEF issued flip charts in December-end as a teacher training tool, with graphic depictions of the male and female anatomies.

The storm of protest is yet to die with six states (Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, and Rajasthan) roundly rejecting what UNAIDS director Dennis Broun likes to call the "baby with the bathwater" and writing to the HRD Ministry to end the AEP. This has had several repercussions. The whole debate on sex education, so gingerly begun by NCERT almost 15 years ago, has

THE WRONG TO

New adolescence education modules ineptly introduced by the HRD Ministry



NO RUNNING FROM REALITY:
Adolescent education is not
just about sexuality

BANDEEP SINGH